DEFINITION A claim is a single piece of information about a principal; it consists of a *claim type* and an optional *value*.

Claims can also be indirectly related to permissions and authorization, so you could have a claim called `HasAdminAccess` or `IsVipCustomer`. These would be stored in the same way—as claims associated with the user principal.

NOTE Earlier versions of ASP.NET used a role-based approach to security rather than a claims-based approach. The `ClaimsPrincipal` used in ASP.NET Core is compatible with this approach for legacy reasons, but you should use the claims-based approach for new apps.

Kestrel assigns a user principal to every request that arrives at your app. Initially, that principal is a generic, anonymous, unauthenticated principal with no claims. How do you log in, and how does ASP.NET Core know that you've logged in on subsequent requests?

In the next section we'll look at how authentication works in a traditional web app using ASP.NET Core and the process of signing into a user account.

23.1.2 Authentication in ASP.NET Core: Services and middleware

Adding authentication to any web app involves a few moving parts. The same general process applies whether you're building a traditional web app or a client-side app (though there are often differences in the latter, as I discuss in chapter 25):

1. The client sends an identifier and a secret to the app to identify the current user. For example, you could send an email address (identifier) and a password (secret).